especially the southern reaches of Kerala, were well-connected with West Asia and even the Roman Empire in Europe. The Syrian Christians and Cochin Jews of Kerala have a history of well over a thousand years due to these connections. Even with Islam, when the faith was founded in the 7th century CE, it arrived in the subcontinent through trade in Kerala, perhaps earlier than the Arab conquest of Sind in the early 8th century CE. Kerala, therefore, became the first point of contact for many foreign cultures in India. Keralites would return the favour by migrating overseas with great fervour in the 20th century.

Mirroring Kerala on the other side of south India, Tamil Nadu was home to a vibrant culture in ancient India, replete with sophisticated urbanization and magnificent temple building.[36] The Gupta Empire's patronage of Vedic culture influenced the religious outlook of south India to a certain extent in the first millennium CE. There were extensive links with South East Asia, such that since the 4th century CE, political states in South East Asia also began adopting many of these Indian cultural practices.[37] The Chola Empire (c. 850 CE–1250 CE) marked the pinnacle of Tamil achievements, witnessing raids by Rajendra I on Sri Lanka and the ports of Srivijaya in the Strait of Malacca in the 11th century CE and envoys being dispatched to the Chinese court as part of efforts to seek greater control over the east–west trade in the Indian Ocean.[38]

There were other instances too of outmigration from the Indian subcontinent that were recorded in ancient India. The returning armies of Alexander and other invaders took back many Indians, and elephants, to central Asia and Europe.[39] For centuries, overseas and overland links were principally maintained by merchants, with textiles and spices as key exports and horses and gold comprising key imports, though not much is known about the merchants' activities outside India. Hindu settlements of over 15,000 members were noted in Armenia between the 2nd century BCE to the early 4th century CE, with references to initial flight due to persecution in north India and wars with early propagators of Christianity.[40] Their disappearance remains unexplained. Buddhist missionaries from India such